

THE RED KITE

Written by

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Self-written sample screenplay for Panelwise.
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FADE IN:

1 EXT. FLAT ROOF - DAY

1

A flat tin roof above a row of small brick houses. Washing lines snap in the wind. The sky is huge and blue.

LERATO (10), braids tied back, grips a RED KITE almost as tall as she is. Its tail is a string of knotted yellow ribbons.

LERATO
(to the sky)
Come on. Come on, wind.

A gust tears the kite out of her hands. It climbs, swoops, and dives straight into the washing line.

LERATO
No, no, no!

MOKGOSI (O.S.)
Is that my good shirt you are flying?

LERATO
It's the wind's fault!

2 INT. MOKGOSI'S WORKSHOP - CONTINUOUS

2

A cramped room under the stairs. Shelves of old radios with their backs off, wires spilling out like roots. One bare bulb.

MOKGOSI (70s), reading glasses pushed up on his forehead, solders a wire with a hot iron. A thin ribbon of smoke rises.

Lerato bursts in with the kite under her arm. One yellow ribbon has torn loose.

LERATO
Grandpa, the string is too short.
It only goes as high as the washing.

MOKGOSI
(not looking up)
Then the washing is winning. A kite is only as brave as its string, my girl. Short string, small sky. Long string, big sky.

He sets the iron in its stand, opens a drawer and lifts out a SPOOL OF BLUE STRING, fat as a loaf of bread.

MOKGOSI

Your grandmother bought this for a kite she never finished.

LERATO

Can I have all of it?

MOKGOSI

All of it. But listen to me.

On the shelf, a radio crackles to life.

RADIO ANNOUNCER (V.O.)

Strong winds this afternoon, with a storm moving in from the west before dark.

MOKGOSI

You hear that? When the sky goes grey, you bring it down.

LERATO

I promise.

3 EXT. FLAT ROOF - LATER

3

The red kite is high now, a bright speck against clouds turning the colour of ash. The blue string hums in the wind.

Lerato leans back against the pull, grinning.

LERATO

Grandpa! Look how high it is! It's higher than the church tower and higher than the pigeons. I think it can see the whole city from up there, every roof, every street, even our washing line. Maybe it can see Grandma's old house. Maybe it can see the sea!

Thunder rolls across the roofs. The string goes tight, then tighter.

SNAP.

The kite drifts away over the houses, trailing its yellow ribbons, and is gone.

Lerato stares at the empty spool in her hands.

4 EXT. NARROW STREET - NIGHT

4

The storm has come and gone. The tar shines under the streetlights. Lerato walks alone with a TORCH, its beam sweeping over walls and gutters.

At the corner, the red kite hangs from a STREETLIGHT, torn and dripping, its yellow ribbons stirring in the last of the wind.

LERATO
(whispering)
There you are.

MOKGOSI (O.S.)
Lerato! Lerato, where are you?

LERATO
Here! Grandpa, I found it!

Mokgosi hurries around the corner under a black umbrella, his slippers soaked through. He looks up at the kite, then down at her.

MOKGOSI
You promised me.

LERATO
I know. I forgot to look at the sky. I was only looking at the kite.

Mokgosi hooks the handle of the umbrella over the kite's tail and gently pulls it free.

5 INT. MOKGOSI'S WORKSHOP - NIGHT

5

The bare bulb is on. The red kite lies across the workbench, its torn paper patched with a page from an old newspaper.

Mokgosi ties the last knot in the blue string. Lerato, wrapped in a towel, paints her name on the patch with a small brush.

MOKGOSI
Tomorrow we fly it together. Your grandmother used to say the sky tells you everything, if you remember to look up. She was right about most things.

LERATO
And we watch the sky, Grandpa.
(MORE)

LERATO (CONT'D)
Every single minute. I won't even
blink. Not once. Not even when the
pigeons come.

MOKGOSI
(smiling)
And we watch the sky.

He switches off the soldering iron. On the shelf, the radio
plays soft music.

FADE OUT.